

Learning to Master the Universe and to Transform Self

Although many observers of cultures have noted general differences between Western and Confucian philosophy,¹ few have analyzed the differences in learning approaches. The purpose of this chapter is to outline both cultures' foundational outlooks on learning. By tracing leitmotifs of these different intellectual traditions, I hope to establish the basis for examining and interpreting empirical research findings that will be discussed in later chapters.

A brief review of recorded history reveals that both cultures have rich, long-standing, and influential outlooks, *weltanschauung*, on learning. Each outlook is an essential part of their respective philosophy. Both outlooks, by the sheer fact that they are distinguishable from one another, can be analyzed as framed by their fundamental questions about learning. These questions have been guiding their thinkers in pursuing their work. Intellectual pursuit resulted in the generation of schools of thought and theories about the world and human life. In response to changing times, later thinkers modified existing paradigms of thinking and developed new ideas. This pattern of idea production continues and is similar in both cultures' intellectual histories.

Despite these general patterns, the two cultures' intellectual traditions started out with quite different interests and premises and evolved thereafter along their own paths. As such, they did not and are still not likely to intersect or, as has been suggested, to merge in the foreseeable future. The Confucian scholar Shuming Liang,² who was also well versed in Western thought, captured this divergence succinctly: If you follow the Western way of knowing and learning, it is unlikely that you will end at the Confucian way. Likewise, if you follow the Confucian approach, you will have little chance of landing in the Western approach. For my purposes, I have identified four themes that I believe are important to consider in the Western

intellectual tradition. Each will be discussed in a separate section under the respective headings: know the world, certainty of knowledge, mind and its wonders, and examined life. Likewise, I have also identified four main themes to consider in the Confucian intellectual tradition. These carry the headings of perfect self (完善自我), take the world upon oneself (以天下為己任), learning virtues (學習美德), and action is better than words (行勝於言). Each culture's sections end with a discussion of the concept *learner* in that culture. Let us examine the Western tradition first.

WESTERN INTELLECTUAL TRADITION

Know the World

Opening books on Western intellectual history,³ one encounters the central focus of learning, from the earliest times to the present, on human epistemology. As an essential philosophical concept in the West, the term *epistemology* is an amalgamation of Greek *ἐπιστήμη* (*episteme*), meaning “knowledge,” and *λόγος* (*logos*), or “principle,” thus creating its current meaning – “theory of knowledge.” Epistemology is a branch of philosophy that studies the nature and scope of human knowledge.⁴ A textbook definition of epistemological studies includes questions such as what is knowledge, how is knowledge acquired, what do people know, and how do we know what we know.

However, a discussion of Western and Confucian differences cannot proceed with this within-culture frame of questions as a starting point. Clearly, all of these questions already assume an implicit agreement of the legitimacy or validity of the concept of “knowledge.” As will be seen later in the chapter, this assumption is not shared when the two cultures' outlooks are set side by side. For the purposes of the present book, but more importantly from a cultural perspective, I start with a question at a more general level applicable to both cultures (or any culture, for that matter). This question does not favor one culture's delineation of knowledge and knowing over that of the other, but rather puts them on equal footing: “What are humans to know?” – however the term *know* might be defined. The weight of this question is on the notion of *what*, and it probes the key issue of what is *important* for humans to know or what *ought* humans bother to know first.

The response to the aforementioned question, from what I can gather in reviewing Western intellectual history, is the *external* world. Humans are conceived of as the knowers. Here the notion of *knower* does not address

any degree of certainty of knowing. The external world is the object to be known by humans. The notion used here only concerns the observation that humans take mental action to try to know and do end up knowing some things, or at least they believe they do. The concept of the external world has undergone gradual expansion, from a narrower scope of the physical world, to spiritual world, to social world, and finally to the all-encompassing world. Still, all of the versions of the world remain external to the person who does the knowing.

Generally speaking, the external world has been approached from two discernable levels. The first is what meets the eye, the sense-data as philosophers refer to it – that is, things directly sensible and experienced by humans. The interest at this level is to figure out how such things are related and function as a whole. The second level, which assumes much more importance in the Western view,⁵ is the underlying, deep forces that cause and drive the surface things; it is uncovering the essence, the stable quality behind the unstable and changing things.

The epistemological frame of the external world as the object of human knowing was first delineated by the Greeks. The early Greek thinkers dealt with both levels. Some tried to link surface things, but those who made a name in history were more interested in knowing the *nature*, the deeper essence of the external world. They wanted to know what the physical world is made of and how it operates. In contemplating the substances of the world, for example, Thales (ca. 640–546 BCE) was recorded to have said that everything is made of water. Anaximander (ca. 611–547 BCE) had his own claim that all things come from a single primal substance, which is infinite, eternal, and ageless. Heraclitus (535–475 BCE) believed that fire is the primordial element out of which everything else arises. Anaximenes (585–528 BCE) declared that the fundamental substance of which the universe is made is air, which was subsequently regarded as a separate substance by Empedocles (ca. 490–430 BCE). More amazing was Anaxagoras (ca. 500–428 BCE) who held that the world is infinitely divisible and that even the smallest part of matter contains each element.

In pondering regularities and laws of the universe, they argued about the shapes of moving bodies, motions, and the temporal nature of the moving world. For example, they conjectured that the celestial bodies moved in perfect circles. Pythagoras (ca. 570–ca. 490 BCE) even discovered that the earth is spherical. At one end, Heraclitus argued that the world is in constant flux as he illustrated with his well-known case: “[Y]ou cannot step twice into the same river; for fresh water is ever flowing in upon you”

(and “the sun is new every day”). At the other end, Parmenides (ca. 515–ca. 450 BCE) and Zeno (ca. 490 BC–ca. 430 BCE) contended that the world is eternal and nothing changes, countering Heraclitus’ claim.⁶

These Greek thinkers showed an extraordinary attitude and style toward the material world, one that Russell called “disinterested effort”⁷ to understand the world. On the one hand, they had profound curiosity about and fascination with the external world, namely displaying childlike innocence that was “imaginative and vigorous and filled with the delight of adventure.”⁸ They were interested in everything – stars, winds, sea turtles, beans, gods, morality. On the other hand, their contemplation of the world was serene, exhibiting a genuinely scientific spirit, even by today’s standards. They hypothesized about the world and argued with each other about their ideas; some even tested their hypotheses. Later Greek thinking was taken up by religious devotion: The object of human knowing was no longer merely the physical world but the divine spirit behind it, conceived of as absolute and perfect. However, modern science in the seventeenth century reclaimed this early Greek stance toward the physical and eventually mechanical world. This stance, as scientists and scientific historians readily agree,⁹ ought to be, and has been since, held as the core scientific approach for generations to follow. Needless to say, this model has successfully led great Western scientists to achieve their celebrated breakthroughs.

However, knowing the world is not the only goal of studying and inquiring. Mastering the world in order to control it and to utilize our knowledge to serve human needs has also been a clear goal in the West. Humanity, especially in the West, was slow to accomplish this latter goal during the first several millennia. In time, human knowledge, particularly scientific knowledge, has been used to eliminate deadly diseases, improve health, reduce hunger, provide shelter to large populations, increase efficiency in productivity, generate wealth, and enhance convenience of life in just about every possible way. These achievements notwithstanding, the last two centuries have witnessed unprecedented and ruthless human exploitation of nature. Consequently, more difficult problems have also been created by human activity, with the most serious ones coming as a result of scientific discoveries (e.g., nuclear weaponry and industrial pollution). This trend of destruction is accelerating at such a pace that, if no effective counterforces intervene, the earth’s resources will soon be exhausted and real man-made disaster is likely to ensue. However, we remain hopeful that by studying the physical and the human world we will find solutions to these problems.

Certainty of Knowledge

Beyond the basic interest in and stance toward the external world, Western intellectual tradition was further established by its serious pursuit of the key epistemological question: How do we know what we know? This question embeds the related set of questions such as “How does knowledge differ from belief?” and “How certain is human knowledge?”

The basic belief that the external world is knowable to humans also came from Greek antiquity. This belief gave birth to what has been referred to as rationalism, which holds that the world is orderly and that we can comprehend it. Rationalist tendency shaped the approach that values reason, mind, analysis, and abstract thinking more than intuition, emotion, social knowing, and experiential learning.

The Greeks discovered logic (discovered by Parmenides and later formalized by Aristotle, 384–322 BCE), which is the very foundation of reasoning. They favored deduction and used it to prove the existence of physical relationships and forces that the native eye could not see. They believed that they could obtain certainty of knowledge and discover things about the world by first noticing what is self-evident, called the axioms, and then by using deductive reasoning to arrive at theorems or other logical conclusions that are far from self-evident. This method of obtaining knowledge was predominant, and it influenced most Western thinkers.

Perhaps the most significant discovery by Greeks was mathematics, which is even more certain and powerful than logic itself. For this reason, Pythagoras was acclaimed as “one of the greatest men [who] ever lived”¹⁰; it was he who used mathematics to express the ideal of contemplative life. Russell remarks:

It might seem that the empirical philosopher is the slave of his material, but that the pure mathematician, like the musician, is a free creator of his world of ordered beauty. . . . Mathematical knowledge appeared to be certain, exact, and applicable to the real world; moreover, it was obtained by mere thinking, without the need of observation. Consequently, it was thought to supply an ideal from which every-day empirical knowledge fell short. It was supposed on the basis of mathematics, that thought is superior to sense.¹¹

Because mathematical knowledge was certain and absolute, it also gave rise to the belief that there was “eternal and exact truth as well as the super-sensible and intelligible world.”¹² Socrates (469–399 BCE) and Plato (428–348 BCE) were also two advocates for certainty of knowledge and eternal

truth. Plato said in his *Republic* that “geometry compels one to look at being.... For geometrical knowing is of what is always.”¹³ In Greek antiquity, mathematics and logic were also used to glorify gods and the immortal soul, but in subsequent centuries they became the means Christian theologians and scholars used to prove God’s existence, His absolute knowledge, His perfectness, and His power. For example, reason and logic were used by St. Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274), based on Aristotle’s argument of the unmoved mover, to prove that God is the unmoved mover of all things in the universe.

The edifice of mathematics, deductive logic, and reason ruled and impelled the search for eternity and absolute truth for millennia. For a long time, there was no alternative way to inquire into the external world. Both philosophers and scientists were committed to this search and relied on these tools to pursue their work. Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo, Leibniz, and Newton were the founding giants of modern science in the seventeenth century, and all of their achievements are testimonies to the power of mathematics, logic, and reasoning (along with available but limited observations and facts).

Francis Bacon’s inductive method was introduced and accepted as a systematic way of Western scientific inquiry in the seventeenth century. Even though Bacon criticized medieval science and made his great methodological contributions, he did not aim at challenging the search for true knowledge itself. Instead, he energized the inquiry with a more viable method. Neither did John Locke in the eighteenth century abandon reason with his radical idea of all knowledge coming from experience. Quite the contrary, he maintained that rational people should hold their opinions with some measure of doubt and that even religious revelation must be judged by reason. Therefore, reason remained supreme for him.

Reason triumphed again in philosophy. Immanuel Kant (1724–1804), a Western philosophical icon in the eighteenth century and onward, wrote *The Critique of Pure Reason*¹⁴ to distinguish knowledge that is a priori from knowledge that is not. Through pure thinking, Kant arrived at his mental categories, namely quantity, quality, relation, and modality (along with subcategories for each), into which, he claimed, the human mental apparatus was to always filter its experiences rationally (such as permanently wearing rosy spectacles to look at the world). Accordingly, humans have a priori ways of looking at and processing the world. Thus, human knowledge consists not only of mathematics and logic a priori, but also of various other categories a priori, even though this latter kind of knowledge comes from experience first. Moreover, he deduced his well-known

“categorical imperative”¹⁵ in his moral theory and argued that all moral concepts originate wholly a priori from reason.

The standard of acceptable knowledge has changed much over the past three centuries. As a result, modern epistemology throws certainty of knowledge into doubt, and absolute truth as a standard has become probabilistic degrees, patterns, and trends in many scientific fields.¹⁶ However, I would argue that the basic question of how certainly we know anything in any scientific field is still a commonly used gauge to evaluate reliable, if not true, knowledge from unreliable information. And no knowledge can be evaluated without sound reasoning. This evaluative frame is applied to social sciences as well as nonscientific fields such as criminal and civil litigation and judgment (e.g., a criminal can be judged guilty beyond reasonable, but not absolute, doubt). Thus, the central role of mathematics and logic reasoning in science and other areas of intellectual pursuit remains unquestioned to date and is likely to last for long in the West.

Mind and Its Wonders

So far I have discussed the questions of what the West regards as important for humans to know and what primary means or methods were developed to obtain reliable knowledge. There is another important question that cannot be ignored in any discussion of knowledge and knowing – and by implication, learning – in the West. This question is “What in us does the knowing?” The discussions in previous sections bear on this very question, but they did not focus on the human knower per se. The part of the human existence in charge of knowing is human intellect, the mind, which is understood as a human faculty, and later in psychology as capacity, and most recently in neuroscience as human brain circuitry. This intellect is endowed with our ability to follow logic, to compare and contrast, to analyze, and to generalize – in sum, to be rational.

What can this human faculty do for us to get knowledge? Again, the Greeks were the first to ponder this question. The best-known thinkers were Socrates¹⁷ and Plato, and their ideas proved to be powerful and long-lasting. Socrates held that human knowledge is not learned but recalled, that the human mind possesses knowledge at birth. One knows without being taught and without learning. He demonstrated his claim by tutoring a slave boy who at the beginning knew nothing about geometry but stated the conclusions correctly himself. Of course, the boy would not have come to the knowledge if Socrates did not guide him question by question with his acclaimed Socratic tutoring method. Socrates maintained that the only

skills learned are those that serve mundane functions such as horseback riding, archery, and crafts (including playing music instruments and making statues!). Higher human knowledge, particularly the mathematical and logical kind, is innate.

Plato also advanced his theory of ideas. Accordingly, the human mind has “ideas” or “forms” for all things it knows (a condition that, from our current perspective, has to do with words we use in the language we speak). Our language has words with meanings, some of which denote more concrete ideas (Plato only discussed the notion of “idea” or “form” but not how to abstract concepts from perceived reality) whereas others denote the more abstract category. Take dogs as an example. There are individual dogs, and we can refer to them as “this dog” or “that dog.” But all dogs belong to the category “dog.” In Plato’s theory, this category “dog” is the universal dogginess that is shared by all dogs (today we would just place this species of animals on Linnaeus’ biological taxonomy). Therefore, the human mind possesses this kind of abstract idea for all things humans see, hear, and sense in the world. Furthermore, Plato claimed that these universal ideas or forms are also *ideals*, and therefore true knowledge for humans to have. The particular things that we experience are not true knowledge but just appearances. Thus, minds that are not used for seeking true knowledge are satisfied with knowing only beautiful or good things, but wise men, philosophers, use their minds to know beauty or the good *itself*. Socrates and Plato argued that it is our intellect, our mind, that achieves this true and ideal kind of knowledge, and therefore the intellect is superior to our senses.

Jennifer Michael Hecht writes in her book *Doubt* that the Greeks recognized the chaotic nature of the world, but they also recognized the power of human rationality that can achieve human transcendence: “What is fascinating is that Plato’s solution is both logical and transcendent. Here one does not use logic to conquer chaos. Rather, one uses logic because the logic itself is beauty, is truth. Plato offers the amazing idea that contemplation of *the way things really are* is, in itself, a purifying process that can bring human beings into the only divinity there is.”¹⁸

Russell points out that because of their abstract nature, mathematics and logic are wholly divorced from the reality that we directly experience. Mathematics and logic happen to be the only kind of knowledge that can be deduced entirely within itself, starting with an axiom, moving lockstepwise to its conclusion. What Socrates proved is not human knowledge per se but our *capacity* to follow logic and proofs. Moreover, I argue that Plato’s theory of ideas can be rethought as nothing more than the human cognitive

capacity to classify objects in a hierarchical structure, from concrete incidences to increasingly more abstract categories, and to use words to map this cognitive structure of our understanding of the world. There is no need to place one type of cognition as higher or lower, because all humans are capable of cognizing all levels as they mature developmentally.¹⁹

Nevertheless, as it turned out, the ideas introduced by Socrates and Plato about the human mind were not whimsical and short-lived. They resurged again and again in Western intellectual history, reaching the pinnacle with Descartes' *cogito* (conventional short form for *cogito ergo sum*, "I think, therefore I am").²⁰ Human existence is proved by the person's metacognitive awareness of his or her own thinking. Descartes (1596–1650) set out to doubt everything, which came to be known as the "Cartesian doubt," and he eventually succeeded in doing so. He could not even be certain of his own existence by any other means except one – his *cogito*. It made him certain that he was thinking; thus he must exist.²¹

It is important to point out that the nativist position of the human mind and its unmatched capacity in the animal kingdom are still alive and well today. Chomsky's initial claim that human language is also a manifestation of this innate capacity, along with subsequent research, has provided hard-to-refute evidence that human linguistic – particularly our rule-bound and generative – capacity is endowed to the species, not learned by or taught to each child after birth.²² Modern science on human infant cognition added the final stamp to the conclusion that we are indeed born with amazing innate capacity to cognize the world.²³

However, the nativist position is not the only one that declares the wonders of our mind. Other thinkers disagreed with the nativist view but savored the mind for other feats nonetheless. Contemporary to Socrates and Plato, Anaxagoras even suggested that mind is a primary cause of physical changes. The idea (perhaps just as bold as those ideas voiced by Socrates and Plato) that the mind can make things happen, along with other similar ideas in later Greek antiquity, may have laid the ground for the eventual theological position that God is omniscient and omnipotent. It was true that the highest power imaginable by humans was, owing to Christian theology, the divine mind that not only created the world out of nothing, but also controls the world and everything in it. Given that humans have been created by divine power, we are also connected to this power. Although we may not fully grasp and possess this power, we are able to recognize it, to hold it in awe, to have faith in it, and to follow it.

Even St. Augustine (354–430), the well-known Catholic bishop in early Christian history, contemplated the nature of the human mind. He discussed

relativity of time as perceived by the mind and argued that neither past nor future, but only present, is reality because we can sense it as it is passing. He held that past is packed in memory and future in expectation. Hence, time is subjective; it is in the human mind, which expects, considers, and remembers. Of course, in St. Augustine's persuasion, the human mind is created by God to begin with.²⁴

The major counterview to the nativist position came from John Locke (1632–1704).²⁵ Admittedly, this perspective emerged much later in history, but it nevertheless was a radical view that could not be dismissed offhand, either then or now. Locke argued that all our knowledge, perhaps aside from logic and mathematics, comes from our experience. There are no such things as innate knowledge, including the Platonic *ideas* as Socrates, Plato, and others had claimed; our mind is a *tabula rasa*, a blank slate on which we put our knowledge, first through our senses and then through the perception of our mental operation. He further contended that all previously said metaphysical knowledge and concepts of the world were not a priori, but rather owing to the language terms we use. Locke's theory of knowledge opened an alternative inquiry into the nature and the workings of our mind, which calls for analysis of our experience and its impact on our mind and knowing. His theory also gave room for the subjective processes of our mental functioning. However, his theory did not dismiss mind itself, but instead pointed to different ways our mind works its wonders.

Two important philosophers followed up on Locke's theory and offered further arguments about the experiential and subjective nature of our mind. George Berkeley (1685–1753)²⁶ maintained that all reality, not just discrete things in the world, is mental. We only perceive qualities of things, not things themselves. For instance, heat and cold are only sensations existing in our minds, and things tasting sweet are perceived as pleasure whereas things tasting bitter are perceived as pain. Pleasure and pain are mental, however, not inherent in the food itself. Whatever we know is already filtered through our mental working. Therefore, only minds and mental events can exist, but not the world independently. David Hume (1711–1776)²⁷ went even further, suggesting that our thinking and reasoning process impressions from our experiences to form simple ideas. Our complex ideas come from both impressions and imaginations. We use language terms to process our ideas. He also contended that much of our knowledge of causality is not from the objects themselves, but from our inference and belief about two things seen constantly conjoined together, with one beginning and the other following. This inference or belief makes us expect the causal relationship. Immanuel Kant, in response to these empiricist challenges and in an attempt to retain

human innate capacity, presented his mental categories to reconcile these opposing views. From the perspective of philosophy as a discipline, these later thinkers may have cast much doubt on human rationality, and one may agree with or refute these later arguments. In my view, whether the human mind is rational or subjective and variable to experience is not important, but that the mind as a topic has received so much philosophical thinking resulting in identifying its many remarkable functions is significant.

The mind's wonders have continued to fascinate Western researchers. Modern psychology was built to do just that, studying mental functions and their manifested behaviors. The whole research on human intelligence and its measures and multiple facets has been and still is one of the hallmarks of modern psychology.²⁸ A century-long research (also from anthropology) involving different peoples across cultures has provided much evidence that human mental processes may share some basic structures such as our beginning capacities to process phonemes, human voices, socioemotional exchange and bonding, and the sequence of language acquisition. But beyond the notion of capacity, human mental processes are, by and large, not uniform, but vary from culture to culture, from ethnicity to ethnicity within diverse cultures, and even from gender to gender. The mind seems to be quite adaptable to the particular cultural and social contexts in which people live. Even for what might appear to be simple categories of color, time, object classification, seeing fish in a tank, looking at a wooden triangle, or weighing contradictions, minds differ across cultural groups and sometimes even between men and women.²⁹ Regardless of how the human mind has been studied, few in the West would doubt its essential role in human life. Current research in psychology, cognitive science, and neuroscience continues to focus on mapping out the precise functions of our mind. As research deepens, more mind's wonders will surely be revealed.

Examined Life

At least since the time that Socrates lived, the West has valued the idea that one ought to examine life. Socrates is also famous for having said in the *Apology* – his purported self-defense before the Athenian jury who condemned him to death – that “the unexamined life is not worth living.”³⁰ His life is a total embodiment of this very conviction.

In every dialog that Plato wrote, Socrates was portrayed as very steadfast in questioning all conventional concepts that people took for granted. He engaged his interlocutors, particularly those who contended that they were sure of their ideas, to answer questions about the meanings of their familiar

concepts. For example, he saw Euthyphro at the court, who was prosecuting his own father for having murdered a laborer who himself was a murderer. Euthyphro told Socrates that his family and friends thought him impious (for a son to prosecute his own father), but Euthyphro found them mistaken and believed that his folks did not understand piety. Socrates took this opportunity to seek the universal definition of piety with Euthyphro as illustrated in the following excerpt between Socrates (S) and Euthyphro (E):

- s: Tell me then, what is the pious, and what the impious, do you say?
E: I say that the pious is to do what I am doing now, to prosecute the wrongdoer, be it about murder or temple robbery or anything else, whether the wrongdoer is your father or your mother or anyone else; not to prosecute is impious ...
s: For now, try to tell me more clearly ... you did not teach me adequately when I asked you what the pious was, but you told me that what you are doing now, prosecuting your father for murder, is pious.
E: And I told you truth, Socrates.
s: Perhaps, you agree, however, that there are many other pious actions.
E: There are.
s: Bear in mind then that I did not bid you tell me one or two of the many pious actions but that form itself that makes all pious actions pious, for you agree that all impious actions are impious and all pious actions pious through one form, or don't you remember?
E: I do.
s: Tell me then what this form itself is, so that I may look upon it, and using it as a model, say that any action of yours or another's that is of that kind is pious, and if that is not that it is not.
E: If that is how you want it, Socrates, that is how I will tell you.
s: That is what I want.
E: Well then, what is dear to the gods is pious, what is not is impious.
s: Splendid, Euthyphro!³¹

Although he allowed Euthyphro to respond and to offer counterarguments, Socrates frequently asked sharp questions (disregarding how Euthyphro would feel about being pushed into a corner). He moved forward one step at a time skillfully, leaving Euthyphro no room but to agree with him, thereby arriving at his general definition of piety in the end.

Socrates displayed his commitment and relentlessness in his pursuit of true knowledge. At his trial, he was accused of corrupting youth (as well as not believing in the gods of the city) because he taught them to question everything as he himself did. He refused to escape from prison when it was possible for him to do so and died, calmly and bravely, drinking the poison as his sentence demanded.

Because of the way he lived his life, because of his teachings, and because of how Plato presented that life, those teachings, and that honorable death, Socrates has come to represent not only the “gadfly” prodding the rich and powerful, but also the sage exercising careful judgments and judicious evaluation. Indeed, he is the very embodiment of not just good thinking but *critical* thinking in the West.

Today, in the West, academic freedom is widely respected. Teachers and students are free to inquire, to think, and to challenge old ideas and express new ones. They are also free to some extent, and obligated to some extent, to challenge authority both in the school or university and in the society at large. As a Western cultural ethos, the inquiring and examining spirit in any form (soft or confrontational) is highly prized.

There have been countless thinkers ever since the Greek antiquity who resemble, if not purposefully follow, the critical spirit of Socrates, with the exception of the long, dark Middle Ages (but there was as also the daring image of Faust). All philosophical, scientific, political, and cultural icons who advanced new knowledge or new ways to solve political and social problems challenged existing canons of thought or status quo. Some were more fierce and radical than others, but all inherited this critical inquiring spirit. Take the eighteenth-century Jean Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778) as an example. In his volume *Emile*,³² Rousseau launched a major attack on educational practice of his day (in addition to his other major attacks on the political and religious system). He claimed that civilization as a whole had done more harm than good to people because it ruins their natural tendencies, which he prized as the ultimate good. In an attempt to radicalize education, he introduced his imaginary and ideal learner, Emile, who has no teachers but only a tutor. Emile is naturally curious about the world, independent in his thinking, innocent in his outlook, and immune to human misery and corruption. Emile learns only according to his inner timetable, and his tutor does not impose anything on the pupil but waits patiently to supply what Emile is ready to learn, to discover for himself. Rousseau’s critical charge probably met much resistance in his own culture and abroad. But his ideas proved to enjoy lasting impact on education down to the present time. Progressive educational traditions in Europe and the United States owe inspiration to him, and the currently much celebrated educational model of Reggio Emilia in Italy also retains the kernel of Rousseau’s thought.

In today’s education, from preschool to university, it remains a central goal to teach students how to think critically. Students are (ideally) encouraged to think for themselves, to raise questions about the subjects they are learning, and to challenge the existing knowledge as well as authority.

An interesting case in point that attests to the enduring nature of the Western intellectual tradition can be offered from the mottos still present in many of the best Western universities' crests in Latin (from a brief Google search): Harvard University's *Veritas* (truth), Yale University's *Lux et veritas* (light and truth), Columbia University's *In lumine Tuo videbimus lumen* (in Thy light shall we see light), University of California, Berkeley's *Fiat lux* (let there be light), University of Oxford's *Dominus illuminatio mea* (the Lord is my light), and University of Cambridge's *Hinc lucem et pocula sacra* ([From] here [we receive] light and sacred draughts). Truth and light convey a similar meaning of the ultimate knowledge. Other universities' mottos stress the mind, the openness, freedom, and critical spirit of inquiry as well as expansion of knowledge: MIT's *Mens et manus* (mind and hand), Stanford University's *Die Luft der Freiheit weht* in German (the wind of freedom blows), University of Chicago's *Crescat scientia; vita excolatur* (let knowledge grow from more to more; and so be human life enriched), University of Heidelberg's *Semper apertus* (the book of learning is always open), and University of Toronto's *Velut arbor ævo* (as a tree through the ages).

One might think that these are vestiges of archaic traditions. However, for each motto found, I saw multiple current discussions linked to it. Students, faculty, administrators, and alumni are actively engaged in interpreting and reinterpreting these crystallized expressions that represent respective universities' fundamental missions. Indeed, each time a new generation of students, faculty, and staff enters the university, the meaning of its motto is reexamined and its spirit revived.

The Western Learner

Within Western intellectual tradition, the concept of the learner did not occupy prominence in philosophical debates. Most thinkers did not write much about the learner as a whole person, but instead focused on the mind. However, despite their primary interest in the nature of knowledge and the mental world, Socrates and Plato (in his *Dialogues*, noticeably his *Republic*) elaborated quite comprehensively on how children should be reared and who among them should be selected to receive the best education (to become the *guardians*) and later to assume leadership as philosopher kings. Some of the later philosophers, namely Locke³³ and Kant,³⁴ also wrote forcefully on the need to educate people. They also offered proposals on how education should take place. Other important education theorists and leaders in the West, particularly, those since the sixteenth century – Comenius, Pestalozzi, Rousseau, Herbart, Froebel, Montessori, American education

theorists Spencer, Dewey, and Kilpatrick, as well as those who have led education reform in the United States in recent decades – have all advocated for the importance of education, with some creating new forms of schooling.

From all of these figures, there seems to be much more suggested for the *provision* of education to children than elaboration on the *learner* him- or herself.³⁵ Nevertheless, one can still discern key assumptions about the learner or characteristics the learner is ideally to possess, as well as the processes in which the learner is desirably to engage to achieve the envisioned educational goals. For the purpose of conducting cultural comparisons, I have identified the following four characteristics and processes for the learner that in my judgment are most central in Western intellectual tradition.³⁶

The first and foremost characteristic of a learner is to have a good mind and to use it well. Individual minds were originally thought to be from the divine source (e.g., Comenius, 1592–1670, took that as a given to launch his education for everyone). Individual minds, therefore, should be enabled to flourish. Later, this divine source was recast into human natural tendency (as advocated by Rousseau and Froebel [1782–1852], the father of the idea and practice of *kindergarten*), and eventually into individual's born potential that needs to be developed fully. The notion of individual potential is still the predominant view held today. It is clear that since Greek antiquity, there has been a strong view that individuals differ in their potential at the outset. Some have greater potential, whereas others may possess ordinary intelligence. Distinguishing the very able learners from the ordinary ones has been important in Western learning tradition.

The mind does not just become great by itself; it needs nurturance to develop fully. For the development of minds, earlier thinkers advocated for strict discipline of children as seen in Plato's *Republic* and the Spartan model.³⁷ Since the seventeenth century, education theorists and practitioners have increasingly promoted intellectual stimulation, nurturance, experience, and social interaction and participation as the processes by which children develop their minds. The purpose of having a well-developed mind is to use it well. Hence, the learner can seek and ascertain reliable knowledge and truth through critical reasoning, as well as reach sound judgments and make informed decisions.

The second characteristic of the learner is to have natural curiosity, interest, playfulness, and intrinsic enjoyment. This valued characteristic directly reflects the much praised Greek stance toward the world. Since the inception of Froebel's kindergarten, children's innocence as well as natural curiosity about, and interest in, the world have been treasured and held as

a central goal for early – and ideally all – formal education. Learners who display curiosity, playfulness, and delight (the notion of *fun* in American preschool and later education) are believed to lead to intrinsic motivation for children to seek knowledge and understand of the world.

The third characteristic of the learner is to inquire into the world. It is important for the learner to maintain an open mind and a free inquiring spirit. A good learner is expected to display his or her intrinsic interest in the world at large on the one hand and to use his or her mind to inquire and to discover on the other. The learner should have what TheodoreSizer calls a “habit of mind”³⁸ to ponder about essentials of the world, to observe, to ask questions, to argue and debate about issues, to challenge existing canons of knowledge and authority (both teachers and experts), and to self-express.

The fourth characteristic of the learner is to understand and to master the world as the ultimate goal of learning. Such learning is manifested in true personal insights, creativity, discoveries, and problem solving. This type of achievement displays the learner’s personal brilliance and calls for reward and celebration. Those achieving the highest level are canonized in the cultural body of knowledge to be transmitted to young generations.³⁹ All the Western philosophers and scientists that have been mentioned in this chapter and many who have not been presented (who are excellent contributors in other fields of intellectual and artistic pursuit) are clear models of the best images of the Western learning tradition. Even those who achieve lesser degrees of excellence – the ordinary learners in daily classroom settings – are rewarded and celebrated for their fresh ideas, thoughtful questions and answers, novel solutions to problems, and often just any form of self-expression. [Figure 2.1](#) shows a diagram of the Western learner.

CONFUCIAN LEARNING TRADITION

It is not my intention here to provide an account of the intellectual development throughout Chinese – or East Asian – history. What is important in this section is to outline the core values of learning purposes and processes.

Perfect Self

The Confucian learning tradition is the predominant tradition throughout Chinese (as well as much of Japanese, Korean, and Vietnamese) history. The single most important thinker for this tradition is Confucius

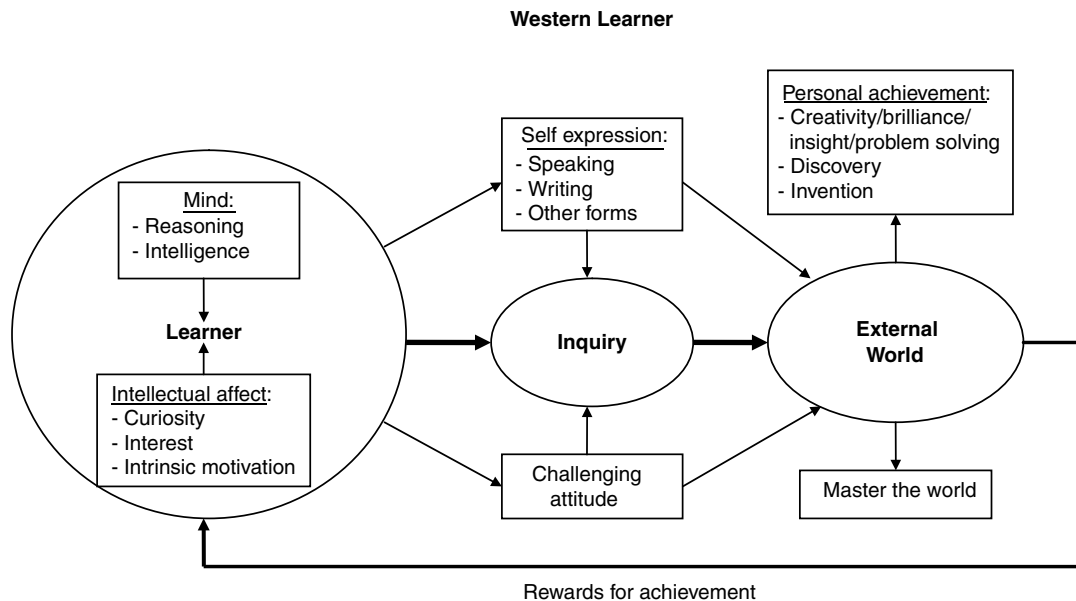


FIGURE 2.1. Western Learner: The basic learning approach is for the learner to study the world out there. In the **Learner**, there are two large components of mind and intellectual affect, with the mind being the most essential. The two most important processes underlying **inquiry** are for the learner to engage in all forms of self-expression on the one hand and challenging authority and the existing canon of knowledge on the other. There are also two outcomes of inquiring into the **external world**: personal creativity and mastery of the world.

(551–479 BCE).⁴⁰ According to scholarly accounts, Confucius did not “invent” the core values himself; he inherited a rich culture that had been in existence for several thousand years. However, “it was he who enabled the millennia-long culture before him to be transmitted, and it was also he who charted the path for later cultural flourishing for millennia after him.” Indeed, one writer, Yizheng Liu, went so far as to say, “Confucius is the center of Chinese culture. Without Confucius, there would be no Chinese culture.”⁴¹ Confucius achieved this impact by compiling the scriptures and texts on religion, philosophy, government, human relations, morality, history, as well as poetry and music. He founded his own school in China and taught some 3,000 students from all walks of life. He was also the first educator in human history to proclaim equality of education for anyone regardless of their social backgrounds and individual differences. If Confucius had only one of the aforementioned accomplishments, his name would remain eternally in the Chinese pantheon. But he achieved all of them. However, the most important legacy that Confucius left is not these compilations, but rather his own teaching on how to be a person, how to learn, and how to achieve human excellence.⁴²

For Confucius, the most important purpose of human life is to self-perfect (自我完善), or self-cultivate (修身, 自我修養), socially and morally. It is the person's self, not the external world, that is the object of his or her intellectual attention, contemplation, practice, and living. The self is the project for the person to work on, to improve, to refine, and to accomplish. Because no one is born with this approach to life, one must *learn* to self-perfect. The sum total of one's lifelong self-perfection constitutes the core meaning of learning. This outline of life's purpose and its process through learning is deeply inspiring to the Chinese and other East Asians (as well as increasingly more non-Asian people in the world).

Counter to the popular belief, the power of Confucius does not focus on the political system, not even political careers of his pupils,⁴³ but the fundamental question that each human being has to face: How do I live my life? What kind of a person do I want to be? These questions assume personal choices, but they are not framed from the perspective of the individual as a biological entity or as a rights-bearing individual as may be the case in the West. These questions concern the very fact that all humans survive, develop, and flourish in social relationships. A person is not just Jenny (or David), but much more importantly a daughter, a sister, a wife, a mother, an aunt, a teacher, a colleague, and so forth. This means that a person's existence is inevitably enmeshed in profound human relationships. As one develops and ages, one's relationships and roles change. These relationships and their associated social and moral significance – not our biology – define our individual *humanity*. How Jenny goes about her roles and relationships with various people, particularly those who are deeply involved in her life (i.e., parents, siblings, spouse, bosses, and friends), will mold Jenny into the kind of person she is and will be. This basic social nature of her life is the very self-project for Jenny to observe, contemplate, practice, and achieve. This lifelong self-project cannot proceed without learning. Ames and Rosemont state that Confucius' vision of human lives was “not simply one to be *understood*, and accepted, modified, or rejected on the basis of its congruence with the world ‘objectively’ perceived. . . . On the contrary, his vision was one that had to be felt, experienced, practiced, and lived. He was interested in how to make one's way in life, not in discovering the ‘truth’” (emphasis in the original).⁴⁴

Confucius and later Confucians outlined what have been called the five cardinal human relationships: (1) parent–child relationship, (2) sibling relationships, (3) husband–wife relationship, (4) basic economic relationship (employer–employee or boss/supervisor–subordinate), and (5) friendship.⁴⁵ Note that the first three relationships, located within the family, are regarded by Confucius and his followers as the most essential. Without

succeeding in the familial relationships, a person is not likely to achieve the other two types of relationship. Since within a family everyone has these relationships, it is then incumbent upon each person to establish and regulate these relationships. Confucius believed that a person who is not able to maintain these fundamental relationships would face difficulties in life. He did not consider such a person to be either able or fit to assume greater responsibilities for the community and society at large.

How then can a person achieve these basic yet very difficult tasks? Confucius taught five virtues corresponding to these relationships for one to learn and four general moral principles for all to strive for. For parent-child relationships, the parent shall show unconditional love (*ai/ciai*, 愛/慈愛) – that is, total commitment to children’s welfare – whereas children express what is known as filial piety (*xiao*, 孝). Unconditional love and filial piety are mutually constitutive. Moral obligation lies in this mutuality. Therefore, parental total commitment and children’s filial piety are not mere emotions (often determined by momentary spurts of feelings), but rather are anchored in corresponding moral obligations to nurture each other’s well-being. So understood and practiced, these obligations shall endure for life.

Confucius talked at great length about the core meaning of filial conduct, for example: “Those today who are filial are considered so because they are able to provide for their parents. But even dogs and horses are given that much care. If you do not have [filial feelings] toward your parents, what is the difference?”⁴⁶ Here Confucius emphasizes the genuine human feelings toward parents as the real difference, not the performance of duties as a formality. The appropriate conduct here is to show filial piety willingly, ungrudgingly, and gladly. Thus, to Confucius, filial piety is the very beginning of all human morality (百善孝為先) now. The assumption is that if one cannot even feel filial love and respect toward one’s parents who gave birth and, often at great sacrifice, nurtured oneself, how can one show love and care to unrelated people?

For the husband-and-wife relationship, the virtue is respect (*jing*, 敬). Respect here is not simply social etiquette, politeness, or obedience that wives owe to husbands as may be understood in popular parlance. Neither is it the kind that Li and Fischer referred to as *ought-respect*, extended to everyone, based on political and legal rights in the West. Instead, respect in this context is a combination of honoring the other as a full human being and at the same time expressing what Li and Fischer termed *affect-respect* of love and admiration in a marriage.⁴⁷

For sibling relationships, the virtue is sibling love and responsibility (*ti*, 悌). Accordingly, the older siblings care for the younger ones whereas the

younger ones remain receptive to and accepting of the care and guidance of the older siblings. *Ti* ensures that siblings continue to stand by one another as a family and look after each other's well-being, prosperity, and moral growth. This is especially important when parents are unable to care for and to guide their children (because of illness, other incapacities, or death).

For the employer–employee (originally king–subject) relationship, the virtue is utmost dedication or loyalty (*zhong*, 忠). This is a basic ethic one has toward work for someone else. The idea is to dedicate oneself to the best of one's ability and without reservation to the cause, the service, or the position. If one agrees to and enters into this relationship, one shall make one's best effort to accomplish the goals. It is simply unethical to cut corners, to provide half-hearted service, to sabotage the work, to engage in conflict of interest, and worse, to betray this relationship. As for many other cultures, this ethical principle is considered very serious.

Finally, for friendship, the principle is trust (*xin*, 信). Although this virtue is also universal across cultures, the Confucian emphasis rests on commitment to friendship and ways that lead to its endurance. Trusting that one's friends will last through good and bad times (同甘苦, 共患難) is key to friendship, and such trust is ideally not conditioned to actual time spent together, physical proximity, oscillating emotions, and changing circumstances.

Beyond these five virtues for these cardinal relationships, Confucius articulated four further moral principles that transcend specific relationships, applicable to common life circumstances: propriety (*li*, 禮), rightness (*yi*, 義), integrity (*lian*, 廉), and a sense of shame (*chi*, 恥).⁴⁸ Ames and Rosemont, in comparing the Confucian moral concepts with those of the West, offer this explanation of the notion of propriety:

[*Li*] are a social grammar that provides each member with a defined place and status within the family, community, and polity [at a given time]. *Li* are life forms transmitted from generation to generation as repositories of meaning, enabling youth to appropriate persisting values and to make them approach to their own situations.... What makes propriety profoundly different from laws or rule is [the] process of making the tradition one's own.⁴⁹

The English term *propriety* does not do full justice to the concept of *li*, which is much more encompassing and penetrating into daily life for the Chinese and other East Asians. The idea of *li* extends from the highest level of ritual performance, such as cultural memorial ceremonies, to one's ancestral offerings, and to the most mundane interpersonal interactions such as giving and receiving gifts, praising and accepting praises, serving dinner, and

the like. *Li* essentially enables people to acknowledge, to attend or attune to, to connect with, to validate, to honor, and ultimately to care for each other.

Rightness, righteousness, or uprightness (*yi*) refers originally to appropriateness of an act in a given situation. But by extension and lived tradition, the term denotes upholding the right things and a sense of justice in human communities, especially when individuals are confronted with lures of self-interest. For example, self-serving at the cost of others is an incidence of not *yi*. Making a promise without the intent of keeping it or simply breaking one's promise are acts of breaching *yi*. Betrayal of friendship, cheating, fraud, and similar acts are also serious violations of *yi*. Mencius (孟子, ca. 372–289 BCE), a well-known sage and a direct follower of Confucius, said that a great person is one who “will not be led into excesses when wealthy and honored nor deflected from his purpose when poor and obscure, nor will he [bend] before superior force.”⁵⁰ The moral conviction possessed by such a person is rightness. The specific behaviors and acts of it in concrete life situations are not stated, but each person ought to develop a sense of rightness so that he or she will know right from wrong and act accordingly in any situation.

Of the four moral principles, *shenzheng* or *lian* is readily matched with the English term personal conduct or *integrity*. Similar to the Western concept, it applies mostly to public life or people who hold leadership positions entrusted to them by communities and organizations. Diligence in performing one's work, a sense of duty, honesty, and clean management of funds are hallmarks of personal integrity. Corruption, greed, and embezzlement of public funds are violations of integrity.

The five virtues for relationships and the three general moral principles are stated in the positive. The last one, sense of shame (*chi*), is stated in the negative. However, unlike the sheer negativity associated with shame in the West, Confucius and his followers greatly emphasized the importance and positivity of shame in human lives. As in the West, shame is a self-conscious emotion that occurs when the self fails socially and morally, often in the presence of others. In Confucian teaching, having a sense of shame is equal to having a nagging conscience, therefore a discretionary capacity for one to recognize one's own wrongdoing (note that shame and guilt are much more closely related in Chinese culture). The most important function of shame, however, is to urge one to correct oneself. To Confucius, not having a sense of shame is tantamount to losing the very human self-corrective capacity. Shame/guilt thus allows room for personal growth. Should one fail any of the desirable virtues and ethnical behaviors, feeling shame is the first response that enables a person to honestly look inward in order to

self-examine, to summon the courage to admit wrongdoing, and then to commit to self-rectification. Mistakes and failures are reasons not to stop self-improving, but to self-perfect further.⁵¹

However, acquiring these virtues and moral principles is not the ultimate end for human excellence. For Confucius, the highest level of self-cultivation is the larger concept of *ren* (仁). The significance of this concept is evinced in the word *ren* occurring 105 times in only about 55 pages of fragmented passages in the *Analects*. *Ren* has been translated as *human goodness*, *benevolence*, *humanity*, *humanheartedness*, and most recently *authoritative conduct*. There is no precise English concept that captures the full meaning of *ren*. Many of Confucius' students asked him about the meaning as well as conduct of and ways to reach *ren*. Each of them represented an individual personality that purportedly possessed admirable moral qualities and superior intellectual abilities and skills. Confucius acknowledged these students' merits but remained reluctant to claim *ren* in them. Therefore, although foundational, merely possessing some virtues and moral qualities or having a superior mind or knowledge does not suffice for *ren*. To Confucius, a truly *ren* person is one who commits him- or herself to a lifelong striving to become the most genuine, sincere, and humane person he or she can become. This life journey is also referred to as following the Way.⁵² This process, Confucius concluded, must be never-ending. It requires that the person charts a path for him- or herself with "vigilant self-watchfulness, in a reverential and respectful spirit, to be exercised in relation to every matter, every action, every thought one becomes engaged in."⁵³ Because each person's actual living circumstances differ, the process is also open and calls for personal creativity. When engaged in seeking *ren*, the person bears witness to his or her own self-project, moving forward with deep joy, satisfaction, and fulfillment. Thus, *ren* is a personally chosen life path that is simultaneously earthly bound and spiritually transcendent.

Confucius preserved a special term for those who commit themselves to the process of and follow the way of *ren*: *junzi* (君子). *Junzi* has been translated as *gentleman* and *nobleman*, and most recently as *exemplary person* by Ames and Rosemont, which, in my view, conveys the meaning much better than previous terms. According to Rosemont,⁵⁴ Confucius spoke of several categories of persons, all of whom display human goodness through dedicated learning. However, the exemplary person is the concept Confucius discussed and savored most (the term *junzi* occurs ninety-one times in the *Analects*). Scholar apprentice (*shi*, 士) is the one who has achieved some virtues and understood the moral principles. This person has also moved beyond the family, kin, and local community,

and is committed to pursue *ren*. Still, much learning and self-cultivation remain ahead.

Compared to a scholar-apprentice, *Junzi* is nearer to the ultimate goal of self-cultivation. Rosemont states:

They have traveled a goodly distance along the way and live a goodly number of roles.... Benefactors to many, they are still beneficiaries of others.... While still capable of anger in the presence of evildoing, they are in their person tranquil.... They ... perform all of their functions not only with skill, but with grace, dignity, and beauty, and they delight in the performances.... Still filial toward parents and elders, they now work on behalf of others ... especially the needy.... [T]heir conduct is not forced, but rather effortless, spontaneous, creative. There is, in sum, a very strong aesthetic and ethical dimension to the life of a *junzi*.⁵⁵

Junzi for Confucius not only cultivate themselves but also help others achieve this height of human excellence. They are viewed as teachers and models for others to emulate; hence, they are exemplary persons. Indeed, *junzi* as described by Confucius is the highest level, and therefore a human ideal, yet it is still possible for most of us to reach.

Confucius did not stop here, however; he pointed to an even “loftier human model,” namely the sage (*sheng*, 聖 or later *shengxian*, 聖賢). He identified some historical figures prior to his time, specifically Emperors Yao, Shun, and Yu, King Wen, King Wu, and most of all the Duke of Zhou, who set the highest possible examples of human moral excellence. Even *junzi* stand in awe of them, and the goal of becoming a sage is out of reach for ordinary people. Confucius’ own assessment aside, there is no doubt that, despite his own humility, Confucius himself together with Mencius have since been regarded as sages by Chinese people. Sages are those who love, care for, and extend their benevolence to all. “Clearly such persons have extended their human feelings and thoughts to embrace the entire human race.”⁵⁶

Ever since Confucius outlined this life purpose and the possibility for humans to reach it, Chinese (as well as other East Asian) people have been inspired by it. Mencius advanced the basic Confucian tenet by arguing that what Confucius promoted presumes human nature to be that which is *not* shared with animals but which is uniquely human (therefore, self-cultivation ought to focus on what is uniquely human). Accordingly, this unique human nature is our moral sense.⁵⁷ Mencius highlighted four endowed human capacities, which he termed four germinations of human moral development: (1) ability to have compassion for others’ suffering, (2) ability to feel shame, (3) ability for courtesy and modesty, and (4) ability

to distinguish right from wrong. He argued that our ability for compassion leads to our *ren*, our ability for shame leads to our sense of rightness, our ability to be courteous and modest leads to our observance of propriety, and our ability to distinguish right from wrong leads to our wisdom (superior knowledge). Mencius' conviction is that moral self-perfection is not reserved to special people or the elite of society, but is available for everyone. By this conviction, Mencius essentially opened the possibility of human excellence to all. However, these human capacities by themselves do not lead to great moral achievement because they are mere germinations. Each individual must make a great effort to *learn* and to self-perfect continuously in order to realize his or her full moral potential.⁵⁸

Elaborating on Confucius' theme of learning for one's self (為己之學, that is, learning to cultivate oneself, not to impress others), Mencius advised learners: "[T]he exemplary person steeps himself in the Way because he wishes to find it in himself (自得之)."⁵⁹ For Neo-Confucians in the Song and Ming periods (960–1279 and 1368–1644, respectively), finding *ren* in oneself became the key to repossessing the Way, thereby reclaiming Confucian purpose and process of learning.

After a much diminished role of Confucian learning tradition for nearly a millennium, the early Song Confucians reopened this learning tradition. The first two influential thinkers were Cheng Hao (程顥, 1032–1085) and Cheng Yi (程頤, 1033–1107), brothers who argued that the Way advocated by Confucius represents the heavenly principle (天理) that underlies all matters in the universe, including human moral nature. Following the Way is reaching the highest principle. However, to follow the Way, one must investigate the principle and its particular manifestations (including understanding physical particularities). The Cheng brothers saw this investigative spirit as a necessary step for one's self-cultivation, one's learning, which was new because early Confucians did not elaborate on individuals' investigation of the universe. Nevertheless, the Cheng brothers reaffirmed that the purpose of learning is to become the sage (notice that they did not focus on *junzi*, but rather on sage directly), the loftiest goal as envisioned by Confucius. The Cheng brothers believed not only that sagehood ought to be the ultimate purpose of every learner, but also that it is reachable by everyone. They outlined more concrete learning processes and methods to guide learners in this pursuit. Thus, one needs to begin by investigating things (格物) in order to extend one's knowledge (致知), which enables one to grasp (getting to the bottom of) the principle (窮理).⁶⁰

Zhu Xi (朱熹, 1130–1200), probably the most well-known Confucian thinker after Confucius and Mencius, was profoundly influenced by

the Cheng brothers. Zhu Xi's thought carries so much affinity to that of the Cheng brothers that their school of thought is called the Cheng-Zhu School. Continuing the basic tenet of the Cheng Brothers, Zhu Xi provided detailed commentaries to the Confucian texts and compiled the *Four Books* (i.e., *Great Learning*, 大學; *the Doctrine of the Mean*, 中庸; *the Analects*, 論語; and *Mencius*, 孟子). These books became what has been regarded as a must-read for every student and scholar until 1949.⁶¹ In the *Great Learning*, Zhu Xi integrated the Cheng Brothers' argument that investigating things and extending one's knowledge are necessary for grasping the heavenly principle. These learning steps are important for self-cultivation, which is foundational for the life path toward sagehood.

The Cheng-Zhu school strongly emphasized complete personal dedication and commitment to this learning. Neo-Confucian learners had many more books and materials to study than their counterparts in Confucius' time. Therefore, studying books (讀書) was a very serious endeavor (in fact, the term *study books* became a general notion standing for education still commonly used today). Borrowing from the Buddhist method of meditation, Confucian learners also adopted quiet sitting and deep contemplation. All of this was to be geared toward getting it (Confucian Way) for oneself because no one else can learn for another. Without achieving this standard of learning, further learning goals are not likely.

Even though the Cheng-Zhu School dominated Chinese education since then, there were also other Confucians who advocated for different aspects of learning. Notably, Wang Yang Ming (王阳明, 1472–1529) argued that human inborn conscience (良知), rather than heavenly principle, is the real governing power, as first discussed by Mencius (i.e., his four germinations). Therefore, learning to become a sage is not just to follow the moral principle, but to extend what is already there to begin with in each person (致良知). He emphasized that people need to hold on to their innate conscience, not allowing negative life circumstances to taint this innate moral knowing of theirs. Furthermore, continuing the Confucian standard of judging moral achievement by one's action rather than by one's words, Wang Yang Ming held that one must practice tirelessly what one knows in order to achieve sagehood (知行合一). This way of thinking opened the otherwise lofty and hard-to-reach goal of sagehood to all people, including commoners, with no regard for social constraints or scholarship (the latter was emphasized by the Cheng-Zhu School). This tenet greatly encouraged ordinary people to pursue the same moral excellence.

Wang Yang Ming also inspired many followers, who, like Zhu Xi, opened many schools and taught many pupils. Since the Ming time, Wang Ken,

Li Zhi, Huang Zongxi, Gu Yanwu, Wang Chuanshan, and Yan Yuan, among others, have either elaborated on Wang Yang Ming's innate conscience doctrine or adhered to his principle of learning and practicing one's moral knowing. Despite their differences in emphasis, all Confucians still share the fundamental purpose as originally outlined by Confucius himself: learning to self-cultivate.⁶²

Take the World Upon Oneself

Confucius' own teaching emphasized personal self-perfection toward *ren* through daily self-examination and practice. Some of his students had ambition to serve the courts (of many small kingdoms). Confucius was very clear that personal gain either for wealth or fame was not part of self-cultivation in his teaching (although he also acknowledged the material need for human survival). The point of serving kings is to ensure *ren* in them. Mencius further clarified the relationship between a *junzi* and a king: The former possesses superior moral power despite lack of political or social power, whereas the latter frequently has the opposite. Therefore, in serving the kings, *junzi* must assume the role of a bearer of moral responsibility as well as a moral teacher/advisor for those in power. Mencius (among other intellectuals of his time) refused to serve any king in any other role or to be "bought" by any of them despite the fact that he was made minister at one court for a few years. Instead, he remained an independent teacher who taught many students and tutored kings and nobles. Moreover, Mencius was exemplary in his insistence on being an independent thinker and voice (not dissimilar to Socrates in this regard). When kings and dukes sought his tutoring, he confronted them critically, urging them to examine their own conduct in order to return to *ren* toward their people. The opening encounter of *Mencius* shows a vivid example:

Mencius went to see King Hui of Liang. "Sir," said the King, "you have come all this distance, thinking nothing of a thousand li.⁶³ You must surely have some way of profiting my state?"

"Your majesty," answered Mencius, "what is the point of mentioning the word 'profit?' All that matters is that there should be *ren* and rightness."⁶⁴

Mencius moved on to reason with the king that if profit is the governing principle in the kingdom, then his ministers will seek to profit themselves, and those at lower ranks will do the same for their own self-interest; soon the whole kingdom will see everyone looking after himself. Then who looks

after the sick, the poor, and the needy who cannot look after themselves? Therefore, a king should not set profiting himself as a priority, but rather providing care and *ren* to his people.

This kind of upholding the moral principle by a single individual, courageous against the abuse of political power and insisting on reforming the ruler to seek *ren*, is the ultimate task for a Confucian learner, known as *taking the world upon oneself*. Mencius was the first to articulate this idea as “taking on the weight of the world.”⁶⁵ “Weight” here is one’s irrevocable responsibility. De Bary explains:

This is in accord with voluntarism in the moral life and of action that is in keeping with “learning for one’s self – that is, with the idea that one must take full responsibility for one’s own actions.... In Neo-Confucianism this is closely associated with the conception of the moral hero.... In turn the idea of taking upon oneself responsibility for the Way, or accepting the duty to uphold it, is predicated on [Zhu Xi’s] view of the individual as a self-determining moral agent.”⁶⁶

In the *Great Learning*, Zhu Xi expanded the Confucian learning path as starting from the Cheng Brothers’ doctrine on grasping the heavenly principle – that is, investigating things (格物) and extending knowledge (致知). He clarified this path to move further to being sincere (誠意) and rectifying the mind (正心) in order to cultivate self (修身), regulate family (齊家), order the state (治國), and ultimately bring peace to the world (平天下). Taking the world upon oneself is reflected in the last two steps. This reformulated path has come down to the Chinese as the process of reaching the sagehood. As pointed out in the previous section, sagehood is not preserved for the privileged elite, but is available to every learner as the ideal and ultimate self. In Zhu Xi’s words, “all men should take responsibility themselves for becoming a sage or worthy. Many men think becoming a sage or a worthy is too lofty a goal and regard themselves as unworthy of it. Therefore, they make no effort to advance toward it.... Yet, the natural endowment is the same in all human beings... how can one not take responsibility oneself for becoming a sage?”⁶⁷

It is thus clear that learning in the Confucian way is not just for personal fulfillment, self-actualization, or personal gain in a practical sense; rather – and more importantly – it moves from an individual starting point and expands gradually to the large spheres of human life as a whole. One begins with a quest for understanding things in the world (note this understanding focuses on the social, not the physical, world). Then one sets one’s heart and mind on the path of lifelong self-cultivation. When one achieves maturity, one has the moral strength and practical skill to

manage one's family. With the family regulated, one is suited to assume greater responsibility in the community, presumably because one has won trust and respect of the people. If one can lead the community (locally or at higher levels) well, one is fit to lead the world. Thus, one's individual self-perfection is not individualistic but has a strong social component from the very beginning.

This ideal of learning may appear unrealistic. Yet, it has remained a high ideal to date. Against prevailing corruption and decline in any given historical era, the Confucian learning tradition has (and here I paraphrase de Bary's remarks originally on Neo-Confucians because I believe that they apply to the whole Confucian learning tradition):

upheld a lofty conception of the dignity, integrity, and independence of the individual learner. It has a high estimate of the moral and spiritual resources of humans, and while its celebration of the heroic virtues may seem hopelessly idealistic to modern minds, it aims ... at the moral nobility of humans, judged on the basis of individual worth [cultivation] rather than special rank or social status.⁶⁸

One historical reason that the Neo-Confucians felt strongly about this path toward sagehood (rather than personal achievement of *junzi* per se) was that almost all of them were court officials. They were called *scholar-officials*, literally scholars-turned-into-officials – a uniquely Confucian elite that served the dynastic courts.

Given the learning aspiration to sagehood, how to ensure that the highly self-cultivated and knowledgeable individuals were able to enter the court government became a serious concern, not only for those who took the world upon themselves, but also for the rulers themselves. Starting in the Han Dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE), such individuals were selected based on local recommendations for the court. This system was called *meritorious service*. In the seventh century, this practice was refined and finally institutionalized as the Civil Service Examination system. Young boys from all backgrounds, not nobility alone, were encouraged to begin learning early on and to persist through disciplined studies. All of them were allowed to take the examinations on their understanding of Confucian texts, their literary skills, and their ideas of governance. The successful ones advanced to higher levels and eventually were selected as scholar-officials who assumed leadership positions at the court. At least in principle, a person could make his way from the humblest background to the highest ministerial office in the land, and the motivational impact for individual learners could not be underestimated. This system lasted for more than thirteen centuries until its abolishment in early twentieth century.⁶⁹

This unprecedented coalescence of moral achievement, academic learning, political power, social status, and economic gain led to the supremacy of learning in Chinese culture. Such learning has become cemented as an unquestionable and nonnegotiable value. Although many scholars were more motivated by material rewards, they nevertheless had to go through the ordeal of the same learning process. Willingness to endure this tremendous process, regardless of their original goals, was already testimony to personal strength and commitment, which was reason for admiration. Those who could advance all the way to the sage level (great leaders) were held in awe, and those who tried their best but did not advance far were still appreciated for their effort. Thus, for Chinese people as a whole, learning to self-cultivate and learning to receive everything else good in life joined forces and passed down through history as one and the same path. As empirical research shows, this way of viewing and engaging in learning has not changed much since then, despite dramatic political, social, and economic changes in recent times.

What about Chinese students learning in the modern educational curriculum, particularly science? Interestingly, the very acceptance of “taking the world upon oneself” as a moral duty for Chinese learners can be said to underlie the massive learning from the West that the Chinese (and other East Asians) have been undertaking for more than a century. As noted in the Introduction to this volume, during the mid-nineteenth century, China encountered the surging powers from the West. The Opium War (1839–1842), and Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895), the Boxer Rebellion (1898–1901), and other confrontations forced the last dynasty to open its door and led to the eventual demise of the dynastic system in 1911. These historical events also led many Chinese intellectuals to blame Confucian learning as the cause of their culture’s decline, because the Chinese lacked Western learning. Many intellectuals and students regarded themselves as the agents of change – that is, taking their world upon themselves – and went to Europe and the United States (as well as Japan for learning how it carried out its political reform and achieved industrial advancement a step ahead) to learn science and democratic thought. Many founding leaders of the two major political parties at that time in China – the Nationalist Party (國民黨) and the Communist Party (共產黨) – were students returning from the West and Japan. The motto held by those studying abroad was “saving our nation and our people” (救國救民). Many other students sought to study science in the West, among them, notably, future Nobel Prize winners in physics C. N. Yang, T. D. Lee, and C. C. Ting. Educational reform took place under

the Nationalist government from 1911 to 1945. As a result, the Chinese education system adopted the U.S. system, and the curriculum from elementary school to higher education has kept up to date with Western mathematics and science as the core, in addition to traditional subjects of Chinese and Chinese history.⁷⁰ In sum, although the learning content has been broadened and the Western-style schooling established, the value of learning and the ways learners engaged in this process still remained quintessentially Confucian, as will be seen in the empirical research in later chapters.

Learning Virtues

The third characteristic of the Confucian learning tradition is the notion of learning virtues, which is personal agency for Confucian learners. Most Confucian writings discuss the core set of learning virtues that any learner has to develop and to exercise in their learning. Thus far I have identified seven core learning virtues: sincerity (誠心), diligence (勤奮), endurance of hardship (刻苦), perseverance (恆心), concentration (專心), respect for teachers (尊師), and humility (謙虛). These are called virtues for two reasons. First, they have long been part of Chinese moral discourse. As such, they denote personal qualities and dispositions that are regarded as highly positive and desirable for any learner. Second, parents, teachers, and society at large make concerted efforts to foster these learning virtues in children; therefore, they are an integral part of Chinese/East Asian education.

As already alluded to previously, sincerity (*chengxin*) is a key virtue for Confucian learning. It stresses the self-chosen nature of a person's decision to pursue *ren* or even sagehood. It is the honest and authentic commitment that the person makes to him- or herself as the target of learning. An example can illustrate the meaning of sincerity for learning. The Cheng Brothers in the Song period had a student who traveled all the way from the south to study with them. On a cold winter day, this student went with a friend to Cheng Hao's place. Upon arrival, he realized that his teacher was napping. He decided to wait outside. It began snowing. His friend could not endure the cold any longer and pleaded with him to awaken the teacher. But the student insisted on waiting. When the teacher woke up, he saw the two men covered in snow. Cheng Hao was deeply moved by the sincerity of these students.⁷¹ This story has passed down as the epitome of sincerity (as well as respect for teacher, discussed in more detail later). Sincerity is regarded as the starting virtue for Confucian learning and prevails through the process.

The second virtue, diligence (*qinfen*), urges the learner, after a sincere commitment has been made, to come to a course of action so that his or her commitment will be followed through. This course of action requires that one exerts oneself and resists any temptation to stray from the path or simply to give up in the face of obstacles. Diligence, thus, is the virtue that underlies frequent, constant, studious behavior. It emphasizes much time spent on learning. Diligence is also believed to increase familiarity, which in turn opens opportunities for mastery.

The third virtue, endurance of hardship (*keku*), focuses on overcoming difficulties one is bound to encounter in learning. Difficulties in the Chinese context mostly mean lack of resources for learning (e.g., poverty) and lack of time for studying because one needs to make a living, usually via harsh physical labor. A learner may also face intellectual difficulties such as not understanding concepts or lacking natural ability. However, no difficulty, irrespective of type and intensity, is reason for giving up. Instead, one needs to develop the virtue of *keku*, where the learner acknowledges difficulties as an inherent part of learning and must find ways to overcome these hardships. There are many models of *keku* from real learners in history that are still widely read to and by schoolchildren. One of them describes Kuang Heng, a great writer and prime minister of the Han Dynasty, whose childhood was very poor. His family could not even afford light at night. To study, he chiseled a hole in the wall to read. His story is the well-known saying “*chiseling a hole in the wall to borrow the neighbor’s light*” (鑿壁偷光), which has inspired later learners.⁷² Not only do many Confucian learners not fear hardship, but they actually take pride in meeting the ordeal, thereby displaying their personal strength.

Whereas *keku* is the virtue in the face of difficulties, perseverance (*hengxin*), the fourth virtue, concerns the *lasting* strength for learning from the beginning to the very end. Two key notions are stressed. First is the belief that learning is a long and gradual process; no sudden insight or shortcut can replace this accumulative process. One’s willingness to follow through is already testimony to one’s attempts to achieve the virtue. Second, the path is full of obstacles and distractions, which demands that one hold fast to the commitment. The following exchange illustrates how a Confucian learner struggles with perseverance: “Ranyou, a student of Confucius, complained that it is not that he did not like Confucius teaching about becoming *ren*, but that he did not have enough strength to follow through with this process. Confucius replied: ‘Those who do not have the strength for it collapse somewhere along the way. But with you, you have drawn your own line before you start.’”⁷³

Ranyou's problem was not his desire for *ren*, but his inability to follow through with action. Perseverance is the virtue that he lacked for he could not even take the first step, as Confucius pointed out. The central meaning of the well-known phrase, "a thousand-mile journey starts from the first step,"⁷⁴ lies in the countless steps it takes to actually cover that "thousand miles." Perseverance is the virtue of holding this long distance in view while taking the first, the second, and all the subsequent steps to reach the end of the journey.

The fifth virtue, concentration (*zhuanxin*), is not exclusive to specific learning tasks, but is rather attributable to any learning. Concentration emphasizes studying with consistent and extended attention and focus. It also includes patience, carefulness, and thoroughness of learning. Concentration is believed to allow the full engagement of one's mind and affect in study. Meditative quiet sitting and retaining a tranquil mind are viewed as conducive for learning.

Respect for teachers (*zunshi*), the sixth virtue, is highly valued in the Confucian tradition. It is closely linked to sincerity and humility (see discussion later). However, respect among East Asian learners has been taken as a sign of obedience, docility, and lack of critical thinking.⁷⁵ The need for respect stems from two mutually constitutive sources. The first is from the learner. As a learner, particularly a beginner, one has much to learn. Respect for the teacher makes the learner receptive to the teacher's guidance. One needs to put one's ego aside in order to make a sincere commitment to learning. Respect acknowledges the student-teacher relationship as follows: the teacher will do his best to instruct the learner, and the learner will do his or her best to learn from the teacher. The pupil is not an equal peer to the teacher. This acceptance of the teacher is not regarded as something that causes the pupil low self-esteem. The pupil's submission to the teacher's teaching is similar to Western people going to a religious minister for guidance. One does not approach such a moral guide with the idea of challenging the minister. If one does not like the minister, one simply goes to someone else. Likewise, Western children take sports or music instrument lessons from private teachers, and learners generally do not approach such teachers with arguments and challenges.

The second source for respect is from the teacher. Teachers in this learning tradition are not just hired as employees to fulfill a contractual obligation, namely to teach objective/scientific knowledge. Teachers serve as moral guides, and for this purpose they themselves must embody moral self-cultivation. In other words, they are viewed as the immediate models for students to emulate. The title *teacher/mentor* comes with the assumption that the person has respectable moral and intellectual achievement

to warrant respect from pupils. Pupils' respect in turn functions to hold teachers accountable for their own continuous self-cultivation. Therefore, the high esteem granted to teachers does not come free. Moreover, in the Chinese (not just the Confucian) tradition, the teacher–student relationship is likened to that of parent–child. Teachers do not just impart specific knowledge, but also must look after the students' well-being as they do for their own children. Unless one is willing to accept the pupils' expectations and the role of a teacher–parent, one does not take on the heavy responsibility of teaching in the Confucian tradition.

The final learning virtue is humility (*qianxu*), which is closely related but not limited to respect for teachers. Humility directs one to regard oneself as always in need of self-improvement no matter how much one has achieved in life. Humility is believed particularly important when one reaches high levels of achievement. In such situations, the natural human emotion is pride. In Confucian tradition, however, pride is viewed as an emotion that may lead one to develop an inflated sense of self, hence distracting one from self-improvement. Humility is likely to prevent one from developing related problems of arrogance or self-conceit. Confucius offers the advice on how to remain humble: “[I]n strolling with only two people, I am bound to find a teacher. Identifying their strengths, I follow them, and identifying their weaknesses, I correct them in myself.”⁷⁶ Humility enables one to want to learn from anyone. Confucius also exemplified humility himself when he acknowledged Xiang Tuo, a prodigious child at age seven, to be his teacher because this child purportedly raised questions to the already well-known Confucius, which he could not answer.⁷⁷ Confucius' humility against the background of his own monumental achievement sets a clear example for Chinese learners. Thus, humility is not regarded as a personal weakness but a personal strength because humble individuals are willing to self-examine, admit their inadequacies, and self-improve.

Action Is Better Than Words

East Asian learners have been widely noted to be quiet in school and reluctant to talk in any public forum. This observation applies to learners in East Asia as well as those in the West (foreign students and immigrants). However, labeling East Asian learners as unengaged, unwilling to participate, or simply withdrawn from the classroom is grossly mistaken. To put this matter in a sharper light, the best Chinese science and technology university, Tsinghua, has the aphorism carved on campus in front of its assembly hall – “Action Is Better Than Words” (行勝於言 or *Facta non Verba* in

Latin) – as their university’s proud spirit (校風). Thus, what speaking means and how it operates in relation to action in Chinese culture (and other East Asian cultures) is an important, albeit hitherto poorly understood, phenomenon (see a more detailed discussion on this topic in [Chapter 8](#)).

Confucius was suspicious and distrustful of glib-tongued talkers. Perhaps for that reason, he did not write anything about his own teaching. He says that “the ancients [great moral leaders] were loath to speak because they would be ashamed if they personally did not live up to what they said,” and “the exemplary person wants to be slow to speak yet quick to act.”⁷⁸ This type of remarks occurs frequently in the *Analects*. To Confucian learners, their words and, for that matter, speaking in general are a very serious matter. There are several clear reasons. First, since the whole point of learning is to cultivate the self morally, the standard of personal progress is one’s moral conduct – that is, what one does rather than what one says. One’s trustworthiness (*xin*, 信) weighs heavily on one’s daily living and conduct. Speaking commits one to the expected action by others, and different types of speaking cause different liabilities for the person. Accordingly, speaking to mislead and deceive deliberately is immoral; speaking without the intention to back oneself up with action is dishonesty; speaking to urge others but not the self to follow through is hypocrisy; speaking without understanding is ignorance; speaking without attending to the context is uncouthness; and speaking to praise oneself is to display self-weakness. None of these consequences reflect well on the person. In sum, speaking in Chinese culture tends to lean toward moral intent and judgment in general. This is why exemplary persons are slow to speak but quick to act. When they speak, they do so with careful words and sincere intentions.⁷⁹

Second, speech is much easier than action; people are more prone to speaking than acting. One area for learners to improve on is to watch out for their tendency to say more than they can deliver. It is believed that one has much to gain by examining one’s own actions and interactions and by bettering oneself rather than merely speaking about one’s behavior.

Third, this learning tradition also emphasizes the great silent breadth and depth that is the realm of infinite wisdom. Lao Tzu’s well-known saying “those who understand are not talkers; talkers don’t understand”⁸⁰ is a clear expression of this belief. Lao Tzu and Confucius agree on this point about human wisdom being much greater than articulated words. As such, Chinese teachers, be they religious teachers, martial arts masters, craftsmen, or Confucian tutors, tend to speak little or speak just enough, but not exhaustively, to leave room for learners to ruminate, digest, and contemplate. Such a way of speaking and instructing is regarded as conducive

to the learners' getting it for themselves (自得). It is rare that the learner and the teacher engage in immediate and lavish verbal exchange. Patience, a virtue related to concentration, is prized in this learning style, whereas impatience is discouraged.

As discussed at the end of the four Western themes, I also performed a Google search for the mottos of iconic Chinese universities in China, Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Singapore. The results revealed sharply contrastive meanings (to those of the Western universities): Tsinghua University's 自強不息, 厚德載物 (strengthen self ceaselessly and cultivate virtue to nurture the world – taken from the *Book of Change*), Beijing University's 勤奮, 嚴謹, 求實, 創新 (diligence, rigor, truthfulness, and creativity – notice the placement of *diligence*); Fudan University's 博學而篤志, 切問而近思 (learn broadly and focus on your purpose, question earnestly and reflect closely – taken verbatim from the *Analects*), Nanjing University's 誠朴雄偉, 勵學敦行 (be sincere and hold high aspirations, learn diligently and practice earnestly – taken from the *Book of Rites*), Jinan University's 忠信篤敬 (utmost dedication, trust, earnestness, and respect), Wuhan University's 自強, 弘毅, 求是, 拓新 (strengthen yourself, carry forward your resolution, seek truth, and create anew), Xiamen University's 自強不息, 止于至善 (strengthen self ceaselessly and strive for the highest good), National University of Taiwan's 敦品, 勵學, 愛國, 愛人 (cultivate virtue, advance intellect; love one's country, love one's people), Hong Kong University's 明德格物 (*Sapientia et virtus* in Latin, cultivate virtue and investigate things – taken verbatim from the *Great Learning*), Hong Kong Chinese University's 博文約禮 (learn broadly of culture and discipline learning with propriety), and National University of Singapore's *per ardua ad alta* in Latin (through hard work, great things are achieved).

Most of these words, as hinted, were taken either directly or condensed from Confucian texts, and they unambiguously and unanimously emphasize the cultivation of one's morals and one's self, which must precede inquiry into the world. Even when truth or fact seeking and creativity are mentioned, it is often the case that they are placed after the Confucian learning purposes and processes are laid down. It is also important to note that the idea of *university* was not a concept of Chinese learning. Most Chinese universities were founded and modeled after Western universities in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, when China was undergoing dramatic political, social, and economic changes. Even so, Confucian learning purposes and processes assumed the first and foremost importance. Again, these mottos enjoy the enduring impact similar to those from Western universities. They, too, convey the central educational missions

of their respective universities to the students, faculty, administrators, and staff. Their contemporary relevance is again evident by the many links to lively discussions in the Google search by each university's community.

The Chinese Learner

The foregoing four sections on the Confucian learning tradition offer explicit expectations and characteristics of their learners. Instead of reiterating them here, I provide a summary note: The learner starts learning literacy and numeracy and other basics of the world including Western subjects of modern schooling. Upon reaching the age of maturity (which can vary from individual to individual), the learner ideally makes a commitment to learning. Under the guidance of family and teachers, the learner gradually understands the need and possibility to become *ren* (the modern term for this process is *zuoren*, 做人, to learn how to be a person). This path is both individual and social in nature. As such, one needs to practice in the family what one is learning and to increase one's learning through practice. When this task has been achieved, one aspires to take one's community, country, and finally the world upon oneself. This cultural mandate translates into today's parlance as contributing to society (貢獻社會). From the very beginning, the learner is socialized to develop the seven learning virtues. Once developed, they last for a lifetime. [Figure 2.2](#) shows a diagram of the Chinese learner.

Confucius, as an *exemplary teacher for all ages*, reflected on his own learning path toward the end of his life: "From fifteen, my heart-and-mind was set upon learning; from thirty I took my stance; from forty I was no longer doubtful; from fifty I realized the propensities of [heaven]; from sixty my ear was attuned; from seventy I could give my heart-and mind free rein without overstepping the boundaries."⁸¹ Confucius took ten or fifteen years to reach each milestone of self-transformation. He made his sincere commitment to learning at fifteen, rather late from today's perspective. At thirty, he established himself with recognizable achievement; at forty, he would not doubt the path; at fifty, he was in harmony with the world; at sixty, he could hear all people empathetically; and at seventy he no longer agonized about how to act in any situation.

Indeed, Confucius' teaching mirrors his own life of learning, which projects a profound creative, aesthetic, and ethical quality. He did not need to write books; his whole life, as recorded by his students, was and still remains an open book of inexhaustible inspiration for later generations to read, understand, and emulate.

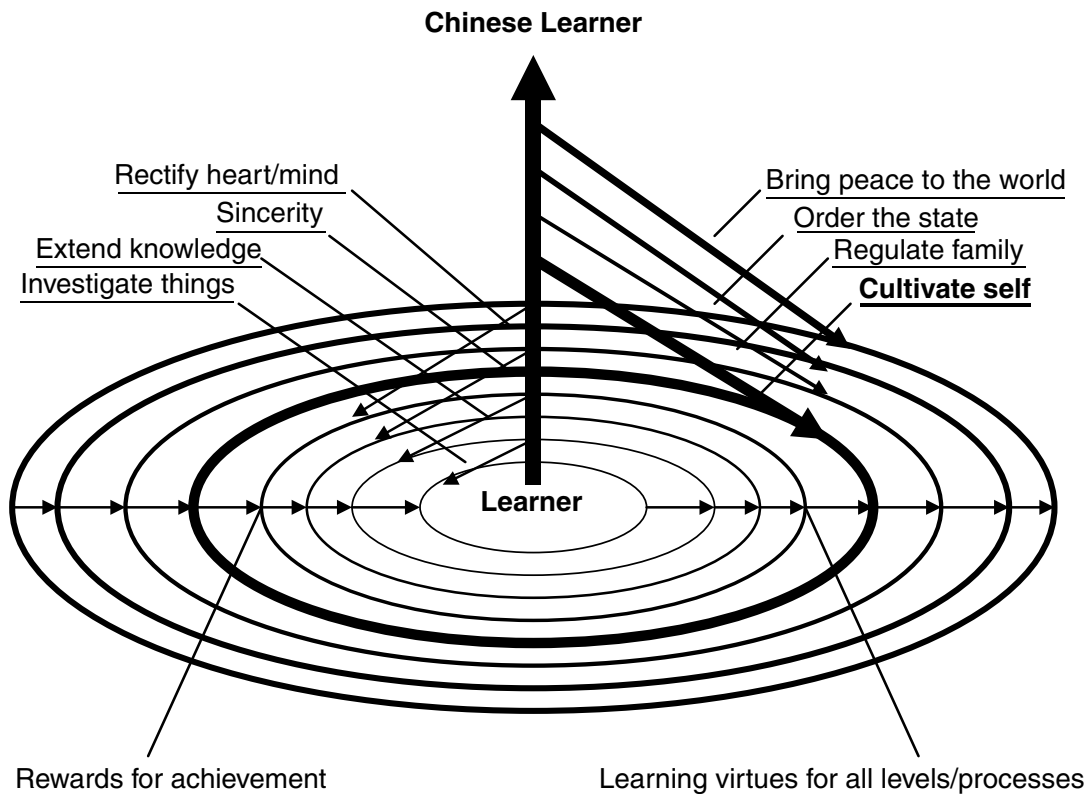


FIGURE 2.2. Chinese Learner: **The four inner circles** have increasing thick lines, representing the first four learning levels. **The fifth circle** has the thickest line, indicating the most important level of self-cultivation as envisioned by Confucius. The circles smaller than the fifth circle do not develop further without self-cultivation, and the larger circles are also not achievable without self-cultivation. The remaining **three circles** have thinner (than the fifth) but still increasingly thicker lines, showing the expansion of one's learning from oneself to one's family, community, and the whole world.

The upward arrow in the center represents the self-perfection process in which the learner engages on the path to becoming a *junzi* and sage, the ideal image of humanity, as held and practiced by Confucians. The upward direction indicates the open-ended and lifelong as well as emotionally uplifting and spiritually transcendent nature of this learning process.

The downward arrows correspond to each level of learning as personal growth in both height and breadth. One's achievement is both individual and social/moral.

The arrows moving away from the learner indicate learning virtues applied to all levels and processes.

The arrows moving toward the learner indicate increasing rewards to the learner as he or she achieves greater levels of learning.

NOTES

1. See Hsu, F. L. K. (1981). *Americans and Chinese: Passage to difference* (3rd ed.). Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press; Ivanhoe, P. J. (2000). *Confucian moral self cultivation* (2nd ed.). Indianapolis, IN: Hackett; Rosemont, H. Jr. (1992). Rights-bearing individuals and role-bearing persons. In M. I. Bockover (Ed.), *Rules, rituals, and responsibility: Essays dedicated to Herbert Fingarette* (pp. 71–101). La Salle, IL: Open Court; Shun, K.-L., & Wong, D. B. (2004). *Confucian ethics*. New York: Cambridge University Press; and Yang, K. S. (Ed.). (1988). *中國人的心理學 [Chinese people's psychology]*. Taipei, Taiwan: Gwei Gwan Tu Shu for samples of thoughtful discussions of differences in general philosophies and ways of life.
2. Li, Y.-T., & Yan, B.-H. (2003). *梁漱溟先生講孔孟 [Liang Shuming on Confucius and Mencius]*. Guilin, China: Guangxi Normal University Press.
3. For discussing Western intellectual tradition, I rely mostly on Russell, B. (1975). *A history of western philosophy and its connection with political and social circumstances from the earliest times to the present day*. New York: Simon & Schuster.
4. See Moser, P. K., & Nat, A. V. (2002). *Human knowledge: Classical and contemporary approaches*. New York: Oxford University Press; Williams, M. (2001). *Problems of knowledge: A critical introduction to epistemology*. New York: Oxford University Press for general philosophical discussion on epistemology.
5. See Ames, R. T., & Rosemont, H. Jr. (1999). *The Analects of Confucius: A philosophical translation*. New York: Ballantine for a good discussion on essentialism in Western thought.
6. All sources and quotes are from the reference in note 3 to this chapter.
7. See note 3 to this chapter, p. 72.
8. See note 3 to this chapter, p. 73.
9. Holton, G. (1973). *Thematic origins of scientific thought*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; and Westfall, R. (1971). *The construction of modern science: Mechanisms and mechanics*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
10. See note 3 to this chapter, p. 29.
11. See note 3 to this chapter, pp. 33–34.
12. See note 3 to this chapter, p. 37.
13. Plato (1991). *The republic of Plato* (2nd ed.). (A. Bloom, Trans.). New York: Basic Books, p. 206.
14. Kant, I. (1787/1999). *Critique of pure reason*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
15. Kant's categories of a priori knowledge and "categorical imperative."
16. See Popper, K. (1972/1989). *Objective knowledge: An evolutionary approach*. Oxford: Oxford University Press for an example.
17. Socrates did not write anything but has come to be known through his student Plato's accounts of his life and thought. Thus, he is commonly referred to as the Platonic Socrates as opposed to another version of Socrates that was portrayed by another, but intellectually much inferior, contemporary, Xenophon. I use the short name Socrates as the Platonic Socrates for convenience.

18. Hecht, J. M. (2003). *Doubt, a history: The great doubters and their legacy of innovation from Socrates and Jesus to Thomas Jefferson and Emily Dickinson*. New York: HarperCollins, p. 20, italics in the original.
19. See Rosch, E. (1978). Principles of categorization. In E. Rosch & B. B. Lloyd (Eds.), *Cognition and categorization* (pp. 27–48). Hillsdale, NJ: Erlbaum for a discussion on human hierarchical categorization of natural objects. See Anglin, J. M. (1977). *Word, object, and conceptual development*. New York: Norton; and Luria, A. R. (1981). *Language and cognition*. New York: Wiley for research on how children have different conceptual understanding of objects and how they acquire the formal structure of word meanings in their language to classify objects.
20. Descartes writes about “Cartesian doubt” in the two books: Descartes, R. (1637/2007). *Discourse on method*. Miami, FL: BN Publishing, and Descartes, R. (1642/2007). *Meditations*. Miami, FL: BN Publishing.
21. In modern views, a person in a vegetative state is biologically alive but unconscious. He or she is certainly not self-aware. Self-awareness necessarily requires thinking of oneself. Therefore, the Cartesian *cogito* is remarkable in that it attaches to human metacognitive thinking, which is thought to be unique in humans and the bare-minimum requirement for us to sense our existence.
22. See Chomsky, N. (1972). *Language and mind*. San Diego, CA: Harcourt; and Pinker, S. (1994). *The language instinct*. New York: Harper for details of how human innate language works.
23. See Piaget, J., & Inhelder, B. (1969). *The psychology of the child* (H. Weaver, Trans.). New York: Basic Books for sample research on human infants’ cognitive capacity; second reference in note 16 to Chapter 1 for infants’ social engagement with caregivers; and Eimas, P. D. (1985). The perception of speech in early infancy. *Scientific American*, 252(1), 66–72 for infants’ phoneme detection.
24. St. Augustine (397/1998). *St. Augustine confessions* (H. Chadwick, Trans.). New York: Oxford University Press.
25. Locke, J. (1690/2008). *An essay concerning human understanding*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
26. Berkeley, G. (1713/2006). *George Berkeley: Three dialogues between Hylas and Philonous*. Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice Hall.
27. Hume, D. (1740/2008). *A treatise of human nature*. Sioux Falls, SD: NuVision.
28. See Gardner, H. (1983). *Frames of mind*. New York: Basic Books; and Sternberg, R. J. (1985). *Beyond IQ: A triarchic theory of human intelligence*. New York: Cambridge University Press for an overview of research on human intelligence.
29. See Nisbett, R. E. (2003). *The geography of thought*. New York: Simon & Schuster for research on these differences between Western and East Asian thinking; Rogoff, B. (2003). *The cultural nature of human development*. New York: Oxford University Press for differences in perceptions of time and age across cultures; Jameson, K. A. (2005). The role of culture in color naming research. *Cross-Cultural Research: The Journal of Comparative Social Science*, 39(1), 88–106 for cultural differences in color perception; and Herlitz, A., & Rehnman, J. (2008). Sex differences in episodic memory. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 17(1), 52–56 for gender difference in facial processing.

30. Plato (1981). *Five dialogues* (G. M. A. Gruber, Trans.). Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, p. 41.
31. See note 30 to this chapter, pp. 9–11.
32. Rousseau, J. J. (1762/1979). *Emil, or on education* (A. Bloom, Trans.). New York: Basic Books.
33. Locke, J. (1693/2007). *Some thoughts concerning education*. Sioux Falls, SD: NuVision.
34. Kant, I. (1803/1960). *Kant on education*. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.
35. Modern educational psychology and child development are the only two and closely related areas of empirical research that focus on the learner and the learning process itself. The review of these two areas will be dealt with in Chapters 3, 4, and 5.
36. Although many early educational philosophers advocated for pupils' moral and character development through formal education, the intellectual and academic types of development dominate in formal education in today's Western world. Moral education is left by and large to family and religion.
37. In his *Life of Lycurgus*, Plutarch eulogized the Spartan system, including how children were taught and strictly disciplined. According to Russell, this book strongly influenced Rousseau, Thomas Arnold, and English public school. The idea that children need to be subjected to strong discipline has never disappeared in childrearing and education practices. Much of religiously endorsed schooling still holds it important to discipline children, although perhaps not so strictly as before (see a good discussion in Jackson, P. W., Boostrom, R. E., & Hansen, D. T. [1993]. *The moral life of schools*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass).
- 38.Sizer, T. R. (1996). *Horace's hope: What works for the American high school*. Boston, MA: Houghton Mifflin.
39. See Olson, D., & Katz, S. (2001). The fourth folk pedagogy. In B. Torff and R. S. Sternberg (Eds.), *Understanding and teaching the intuitive mind* (pp. 243–263). Mahwah, NJ: Erlbaum for an informative discussion of how great intellectuals, scientists, and artists become canonized and hence perpetuated as the impersonal body of knowledge that is to be transmitted to young generations through formal education.
40. See de Bary, W. T. (1991). *Learning for one's self*. New York: Columbia University Press for a comprehensive treatment of the Confucian learning influence on Japan and Korea, and reference in note 5 to this chapter for Confucian influence on Vietnam. The fact that this learning tradition is named after his profession, *Rujia*, 儒家 (not the Latinized name Confucius. During Confucius' time, the term *ru* was used to refer to priests in charge of religious ceremonies for the courts as well as teachers. Because Confucius did such work, his school of thought carries the term *ru*) signifies the important role that Confucius played.
41. Quoted by Shuming Liang, p. 203 in reference in note 2 to this chapter.
42. Despite all the compilations of scriptures and texts, Confucius never wrote anything on his own teaching (much like Socrates). The *Analects of Confucius*, which contains fragmented statements and questions and responses between him and his students, is the primary source from which we glimpse Confucius' thinking and teaching. As many scholars throughout history have argued, some

- of the content may have been modified and added by his students. Nevertheless, the first ten chapters are believed to be Confucius' own words. See Fingarett, H. (1972). *Confucius: The secular as sacred*. New York: Harper & Row and reference in note 5 to this chapter for more discussion on the authenticity of the *Analects*.
43. Although Confucianism became the predominant ideology for all dynastic ruling, Confucius' own teaching did not focus on that. When he talked to his pupils about serving kings and dukes in their courts, it was not for career development but to ensure humane ruling in government. See Li & Yan (2003) in note 2 for more comprehensive discussions on these points by Shuming Liang.
 44. See note 5 to this chapter, p. 5.
 45. To be sure, at the time Confucius lived, the employer–employee relationship was the one between the king and the subject. He also referred to the father–son instead of parent–child relationship given the male-dominant orientation of society at that time. However, this historical condition is less important for our purpose of understanding Confucian teaching of the cardinal relationships as the base for human lives. Today, his teaching is understood as still relevant to the general parent–child and employer–employee relationships.
 46. See note 5, 2.7 to this chapter, p. 77.
 47. Li, J., & Fischer, K. W. (2007). Respect as a positive self-conscious emotion in European Americans and Chinese. In J. L. Tracy, R. W. Robins, & J. P. Tangney (Eds.), *The self-conscious emotions: Theory and research* (pp. 224–242). New York: Guilford. It is important to point out that even though the roles of husband and wife were delineated at the time, Confucius did not state that women were lower than men in their capacity and moral worth. Gender discrimination against women was more a result of later historical development. During Confucius' time, another great sage, Lao Tzu, argued that femininity was an equal (and often neglected) force in the universe.
 48. These four moral principles are carved on the Chinatown gate in Boston, MA. They serve as a monument and reminder of the core Confucian values to Chinese even in a culture vastly different from their own. The term *lian* (廉) was first used not by Confucius himself but by Guanzhong (ca. 723/716–645 BCE), a highly esteemed prime minister of State Qi. Confucius used the term *shenzheng* (身正) to discuss this essential virtue in any government official. *Lian* is the present-day term for integrity.
 49. See note 5 to this chapter, p. 51.
 50. Mencius (1970). *Mencius* (D. C. Lao, Trans.). Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, p. 107.
 51. See Tracy, J. L., & Robins, R. W. (2007). The self in self-conscious emotions: A cognitive appraisal approach. In J. L. Tracy, R. W., Robins, & J. P. Tangney (Eds.), *The self-conscious emotions: Theory and research* (pp. 3–20). New York: Guilford for chapters on the negativity of shame in the West. See Li, J., Wang, L. -Q., & Fischer, K. W. (2004). The organization of Chinese shame concepts. *Cognition and Emotion*, 18(6), 767–797 for research on the meaning of shame in Chinese, and see Fung, H. (1999). Becoming a moral child: The socialization of shame among young Chinese children. *Ethos*, 27, 180–209 for how parents socialize children with a sense of shame in Taiwan.
 52. See Tu, W. M. (1979). *Humanity and self-cultivation: Essays in Confucian thought*. Berkeley, CA: Asian Humanities Press for discussions of *ren*.

53. See note 40 to this chapter, p. 342.
54. See Rosemont, Jr., H. (2003). Is there a universal path of spiritual progress in the texts of early Confucianism? In W. M. Tu & M. E. Tucker (Eds.), *Confucian spirituality*, vol. 1 (pp. 183–196). New York: Crossroad for an insightful discussion of various kinds of persons talked about by Confucius.
55. See note 54 to this chapter, p. 190.
56. See note 54 to this chapter, p. 191.
57. See note 50 in D. C. Lau for Lau's discussion of Mencius's contribution to Confucianism in the introduction to his translation of *Mencius*. Also see Wilson, J. Q. (1993). *The moral sense*. New York: Simon & Schuster for a review of research on human moral sense. There is strong evidence that very young infants are able to display empathy toward other infants with distress. This supports the Mencian argument for innate human moral sensibilities.
58. See note 50 to this chapter, pp. 82–83.
59. See note 50 to this chapter, p. 130. Note that the Chinese term *junzi* is not gendered, although at that time only men could be educated.
60. The Neo-Confucian movement was in part a response to the prevailing Buddhism and Taoism at that time. Whereas Buddhism advocated eradicating human desires altogether (無欲) to achieve enlightenment, Taoism promoted harmony with nature by avoiding human strife and arduous effort for achievement (無為). Neither doctrine appealed to the Confucians because Confucian teaching encouraged individuals to regulate family, serve the community, and take greater social and moral responsibility for one's society. However, Neo-Confucians incorporated some elements to offer a compromise position (e.g., eliminating human desires in order to uphold the heavenly principle and quiet sitting to study taken from Buddhism and arguing that the enduring human values are consistent with the Taoist tenet of the Supreme Ultimate [太極] – as a normative principle and at the same time the Nonfinite [無極] as an open-ended and flexible principle to guide human lives). See reference in note 40 of de Bary for more discussions on the integration of the three different schools of thought.
61. The *Four Books* along with the other *Five Scriptures* (*Book of Changes*, *Book of History*, *Book of Songs*, *Book of Rites*, and the *Spring and Autumn Annals*) were the core curriculum of any Confucian student and were the content of the Civil Service Examinations. These books continued to be required of and read by students even after the abolishment of the Civil Service Examination system in 1905. When the Communists took power in 1949, these books were no longer part of the school curriculum. But they continued to be taught to and read by students in Taiwan. Interestingly, there has been a new movement to teach children Confucian values since the 1990s in Taiwan, which is now rapidly expanding to Mainland China and other Chinese regions (see a review of this topic in the reference in note 9 Chapter 1).
62. See note 40 to this chapter for a comprehensive account of the Cheng-Zhu school and Yang Ming school and their respective influences. Also see Lee, T. H. C. (1999). *Education in Traditional China: A History*. Boston, MA: Brill Academic for a detailed historical account.
63. A *li* is a little more than 400 meters.
64. See note 50 to this chapter, p. 50.

65. See note 40 to this chapter, p. 29. Also see Yu, Y.-S. (2003). *士與中國文化* [Intellectuals and Chinese culture]. Shanghai: Shanghai People's Press for a historical account of the role of Confucian intellectuals.
66. See note 65 to this chapter.
67. See note 40 to this chapter, p. 30.
68. See note 40 to this chapter, p. 37.
69. See Lee, W. O. (1996). The cultural context for Chinese learners: Conceptions of learning in the Confucian tradition. In D. A. Watkins & J. B. Biggs (Eds.), *The Chinese learner* (pp. 45–67). Hong Kong: Comparative Education Research Centre for a discussion on meritorious service; and Lee, T. H. C. (1985). *Government education and examinations in Sung China, 960–1278*. Hong Kong: Chinese University Press for a historical account of the Civil Service Examination system.
70. See Su, Y.-F., & Wu, J.-Y. (2005). *中國新教育的萌芽與成長 (1860–1928)* [The emergence and development of new Chinese education (1860–1928)]. Taipei, Taiwan: Wunan Publishing; and Wu, J.-Y. (1990). *中華民國教育政策發展史 (國民政府時期 1925–1940)* [History of the development of education policy during 1925–1940 under the China's Nationalist government]. Taipei, Taiwan: Wunan Publishing for a thorough treatment on the modern history of Chinese education.
71. Wang, T., et al. (1985). *中國成語大辭典* [Dictionary of Chinese idioms]. Shanghai: Shanghai Dictionary Press, pp. 166–167.
72. See note 71 to this chapter, p. 1816.
73. See note 5 to this chapter, p. 106.
74. Lao Tzu (1992). *The Tao of the Tao Te Ching* (M. LaFargue, Trans.). Albany: State University of New York Press, p. 156.
75. See Pratt, D. D., Kelly, M., & Wong, K. M. (1999). Chinese conceptions of “effective teaching” in Hong Kong: Towards culturally sensitive evaluation of teaching. *International Journal of Lifelong Learning*, 18, 241–258; and Tweed, R. G., & Lehman, D. R. (2002). Learning considered within a cultural context: Confucian and Socratic approaches. *American Psychologist*, 57(2), 89–99 for general discussions on obedience and docility of East Asian students. See also Flowerdew, J., & Miller, L. (1995). On the notion of culture in L2 lectures. *TESOL Quarterly*, 29(2), 345–373, and McGuire, J. (1997). English as a foreign language in China. *Occasional Papers*, 48. University of Southampton: Centre for Language in Education for similar observations in Chinese students.
76. See note 5 to this chapter, p. 116.
77. Huang, D. Y., & Peng, H. J. (1992). *三字經* [Three character classic]. Taipei, Taiwan: Ruisheng Book & Magazine Publishing House, p. 90.
78. See note 5 to this chapter, pp. 93–94.
79. See Chang, H. C. (1997). Language and words: Communication in the *Analects* of Confucius. *Journal of Language and Social Psychology*, 16, 107–131 for a comprehensive discussion on Confucius' treatment of speaking.
80. See note 74 to this chapter, p. 66. Also in Japan, a talkative person, particularly a man, is regarded as unintelligent according to Doi, T. (1981). *The anatomy of dependence* [J. Bester, Trans.]. New York: Kodansha International.
81. See note 5 to this chapter, pp. 76–77.